LIBRARY LESSON PLAN

Harlem Renaissance Library Session

PreK–Kindergarten · 25 minutes · Whole group + table activity

THE 25 MINUTES

3 min	5 min	5 min	9 min	3 min
GATHERING	PICTURE WALK	READ OR LISTEN	ACTIVITY CARD	SHARE

SESSION GOALS

What children will do

Children will: meet Aaron Douglas's art and hear its story; understand that music, painting, and stories are ways people share who they are; practice observing pictures carefully; and create a simple response drawing. **Language goals:** silhouette, music, story, color, Harlem.

PREPARATION

- **Display:** large-format print of Aaron Douglas's *Song of the Towers* (or project from exhibition link)
- **Tables set:** one Green Activity Card per child, crayons, black marker
- **Optional read-aloud:** *The Watcher* by Nikki Grimes or *Duke Ellington* by Andrea Davis Pinkney

SESSION FLOW

0–3 MIN Gathering	Children sit on the rug. *"Today we're going to look at a very special painting and listen to some music that was made a long, long time ago in a place called Harlem, New York. I'm going to play some music — I want you to close your eyes and tell me what color it sounds like."* Play 20 seconds of jazz. Take 3–4 color responses.
3–8 MIN Picture walk	Reveal the Douglas print. *"What do you see? Find the people. What are they doing? What shapes do you notice in the background? Why do you think the artist made the people dark like shadows?"* Accept all responses. Introduce: *"These shadow-shapes are called silhouettes. The artist chose not to show faces — because these people could be anyone. They could be you."*
8–13 MIN Read-aloud or music listen	Read one picture book about the Harlem Renaissance (Ellington or Hughes titles work well) OR play a second piece of jazz and ask children to move their hands like the music. Connect: *"The people in the painting were listening to music just like this. They were making something beautiful."*
13–22 MIN Activity card	Children move to tables. Each child has a Green Activity Card. They draw a silhouette person doing something they love — music, dancing, reading, building — and color the background in their "music color." Circulate: *"Tell me about your person. What are they doing? Why that color?"*
22–25 MIN Share and close	Three children show their drawing to the group. *"You've just done what Aaron Douglas did — you made a picture that tells a story without showing a face. That makes your person everyone."* Return to classrooms with drawings.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the Exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more.

Option 2 — Virtual Visit:

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

BOOK RECOMMENDATIONS

PRIMARY PICKS

Duke Ellington: The Piano Prince and His Orchestra — Andrea Davis Pinkney (1998) — Caldecott Honor; introduces jazz biography accessibly

The Watcher — Nikki Grimes — a poet's picture book, illustrated by Bryan Collier

Ruth and the Green Book — Calvin Alexander Ramsey — Great Migration through a child's eyes

Before She Was Harriet — Lesa Cline-Ransome, illustrated by James E. Ransome — a life told backward in verse

DISPLAY AND EXTENSION

Langston Hughes — Any picture-book adaptations (several exist for young readers)

Harlem — Walter Dean Myers / Christopher Myers (1997)

Stompin' at the Savoy — by the children — a class writing project you could initiate from this session

Print — Aaron Douglas postcards or posters from the Schomburg Center (free high-res downloads available)

VOCABULARY FOR EARLY LEARNERS

Silhouette	a shape that looks like a shadow; Aaron Douglas made people look like this in his paintings
Jazz	a kind of music born in America that uses many instruments at once and lets musicians make up parts as they play
Harlem	a neighborhood in New York City where many Black artists, musicians, and writers lived and worked in the 1920s
Renaissance	a time when lots of beautiful, important things are created all at once (tell children: *"like when a garden blooms all at once in spring"*)

CROSS-CURRICULAR INTEGRATION NOTES

- **Classroom connection:** Share drawings with the classroom teacher as a provocation for discussion about "making something beautiful" and what stories images can tell
- **Music class:** Send the jazz clip recommendation to the music teacher — can be revisited in music with more structured listening
- **Catholic context:** *"Every person in Aaron Douglas's paintings is a shadow — but every shadow also has a light behind it. That light is the light of God in every person."*

Paintings to project (in copyright, so not printed; each title links to the museum's page): Aspects of Negro Life: Song of the Towers (1934) · The Creation (1935)